

took violin lessons and excelled as a pianist, giving his first concert at the age of six.

Smetana attended several schools, including one in Bohemia's capital, Prague. In 1843, he continued his musical training with the blind pianist and composer Josef Proksch, and scraped a living as piano tutor to the five children of Count Leopold Thun.

The brief Prague Revolution that took place in June 1848, in which the city's residents rose up unsuccessfully against Bohemia's Hapsburg rulers, shaped Smetana's awareness of Bohemian nationalism. He wrote several patriotic works in response, including "Song of Freedom." That same year, he opened a Piano Institute in Prague, and in 1849 he married the pianist Kateřina Kolářová, whom he had known since his school days. Despite developing a successful career as a pianist and composer, Smetana felt vastly underappreciated in Prague, and in 1856 left for Gothenburg, Sweden.



LITOMYSL CASTLE

This 16th-century Renaissance arcaded castle was